Lesson 02 material: Pronunciation: Syllables and Word Stress

English Stage 1 (B1) · Unit 1: People and Places

1.3: Counting Syllables

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Changes: formatted for print; exercise answers are in the study guide.

Counting Syllables

Rules to Remember

Rules to Remember: Syllables

We can divide words into syllables to help us pronounce words clearly. Each syllable has only **one** vowel sound and usually one or more consonant sounds. Words have one, two, three or more syllables.

Figure: The image gives examples of one, two and three-syllable words. One-syllable words: sit, cook, eat. Two-syllable words: city, cookie, eating. Three-syllable words: beautiful, banana, easily.

Answer the Questions

EXERCISE

1. How many vowels are in each syllable?
a) one b) two c) three

EXERCISE

1. How many consonants are usually in each syllable?
a) only one b) one or more

Watch the Video: Syllables

Video: https://youtu.be/9S7DY2lgJlU

Answer the Questions

Decide whether each word has one, two, three, or four syllables. Choose the correct answer. Click on "check" to check your answers. Click on the arrow to advance to the next question. When you've answered all the questions, click on "finished."

Practice 1:

EXERCISE

1. How many syllables are in the word "cat"?
a) 1 b) 2 c) 3

2. How many syllables are in the word "scratch"?
a) 1 b) 2 c) 3

3. How many syllables are in the word "ball"?
a) 1 b) 2 c) 3

4. How many syllables are in the word "acorn"?
a) 1 b) 2 c) 3

5. How many syllables are in the word "seven"?
a) 1 b) 2 c) 3

6. How many syllables are in the word "watermelon"?
a) 2 b) 3 c) 4

7. How many syllables are in the word "dog"?
a) 1 b) 2 c) 3

8. How many syllables are in the word "apple"?
a) 1 b) 2 c) 3

9. How many syllables are in the word "ladybug"?
a) 2 b) 3 c) 4

10. How many syllables are in the word "salamander"?
a) 2 b) 3 c) 4

11. How many syllables are in the word "garden"?
a) 2 b) 3 c) 4

12. How many syllables are in the word "unicorn"?
a) 2 b) 3 c) 4

13. How many syllables are in the word "spectacles"?
a) 4 b) 2 c) 3

14. How many syllables are in the word "elephant"?
a) 2 b) 3 c) 4

15. How many syllables are in the word "invisible"?
a) 2 b) 3 c) 4

16. How many syllables are in the word "January"?
a) 2 b) 3 c) 4

Practice 2:

EXERCISE

1. How many syllables are in the word "market"?
a) 2 b) 3 c) 4

2. How many syllables are in the word "neighborhood"?
a) 2 b) 3 c) 4

3. How many syllables are in the word "galleries"?
a) 2 b) 3 c) 4

4. How many syllables are in the word "exude"?
a) 1 b) 2 c) 3

5. How many syllables are in the word "vibe"?
a) 1 b) 2 c) 3

6. How many syllables are in the word "curry"?
a) 1 b) 2 c) 3

7. How many syllables are in the word "powder"?
a) 1 b) 2 c) 3

8. How many syllables are in the word "concotion"?
a) 4 b) 2 c) 3

9. How many syllables are in the word "sausage"?
a) 2 b) 3 c) 4

10. How many syllables are in the word "symbol"?
a) 1 b) 2 c) 3

Divide the Words into Syllables

Write the correct number of syllables for each word. Then divide each word into syllables.

Word	Number of Syllables	Divide the word into syllables
EXAMPLE: memorial	4	me-mor-i-al
graffiti		
infamous		
dangle		
unity		
escape		
wild		
deer		

hangout
vintage

Think of your own words

Write a different word that has the number of syllables shown.

Number of Syllables	EXAMPLE	Your Word	Your Word
one-syllable words	desk		
two-syllable words	pencil		
three-syllable words	chocolate		

Recording

Instructions

- Listen to the video and read the transcript silently. If you don't understand the words, ask your teacher or use a dictionary. Then practice reading aloud.
- Read the text clearly and at a normal pace (not too fast).
- When you're ready, us a camera or a cell phone to record yourself reading the transcript.
- Listen to your recording and check for mistakes. Then record yourself again.
- Submit the recording to your teacher.

Listen and Read

Watch the video and read the transcript. Note: You will only read the introduction, and the first and second place to visit.

Video: https://youtu.be/lw5NHQeXzpA

Transcript

We had heard Berlin was a city bursting with art and music and we were very excited to spend some time there. Here is our list of the 25 best things to do in Berlin.

1. The East Side Gallery is the longest remaining strip of the former dividing wall between East and West Berlin. Today the 1.3 kilometer long wall stands as a memorial to freedom and it is covered in art and graffiti.

2. Right now we're visiting Brandenberg Gate. This gate dates back to the 18th century, and it used to be one of the old gates leading into the city. Now, after the wall came down in 1989 this became a symbol of unity between East and West Germany, so it's an important site to visit.

1.4: Syllable Stress

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https://human.libretexts.org/Bookshelves/Languages/English_as_a_Second_Language/Book%3A_Speaking_Listening_and_Pronunciation_Projects_for_ELLs_-_Intermediate_Level_(Zemlick)/01%3A_People_and_Places/1.04%3A_Syllable_Stress
Changes: formatted for print; exercise answers are in the study guide.

Audio for this section is saved on your computer in `E:\personal-tutor\materials\library\esl-b1-speaking\attachments\01.04-syllable-stress`: Syllable Stress Quiz; Syllable Stress Recording; Syllable Stress Recording Task

Syllable Stress: Which syllable is the strongest?

Rules to Remember

Rules to Remember: Syllable Stress

In words with two or more syllables, one syllable is stronger than the others. The strongest syllable has the most stress or emphasis.

Listen

Listen to the speaker read the words in the figure below. (Audio on the lesson web page: "Syllable Stress Recording")

Figure: The image gives examples of syllable stress in two, three, and four-syllable words. Two-syllable words: apple, repeat, seven. Three-syllable words: ladybug, delicious, understand. Four-syllable words: watermelon, avocado, ability.

Notice:

- The stressed syllable is long and the vowel sound of the stressed syllable is clear.
- The other syllables are short and unclear.
- There is only one syllable with primary stress in each word. The other syllables usually take the schwa sound /ə/.

Watch the Video

Rachel's English - Word Stress in Two-Syllable Words

Video: https://youtu.be/gEpYBLjrO6s

Practice

Underline the stressed syllable in each of the words below.

Example: repeat

1. about
2. daughter
3. sleepy
4. unreal
5. question
6. relax
7. rely
8. quiet
9. perfect
10. allow
11. standard
12. delete

Check your Answers

Use the interactive quiz to check your answers. Select the correct answer, click "check" to see if your answer is correct, and then click the arrow to move to the next question. When you have answered all of the questions, click "Finished."

EXERCISE

1. Which syllable is stressed in the word "about"?
a) 1st syllable: a b) 2nd syllable: bout

2. Which syllable is stressed in the word "daughter"?

a) 1st syllable: daugh b) 2nd syllable: ter

3. Which syllable is stressed in the word "sleepy"?
a) 1st syllable: sleep b) 2nd syllable: y

4. Which syllable is stressed in the word "unreal"?
a) 1st syllable: un b) 2nd syllable: real

5. Which syllable is stressed in the word "question"?
a) 1st syllable: ques b) 2nd syllable: tion

6. Which syllable is stressed in the word "relax"?
a) 1st syllable: re b) 2nd syllable: lax

7. Which syllable is stressed in the word "rely"?
a) 1st syllable: re b) 2nd syllable: ly

8. Which syllable is stressed in the word "quiet"?
a) 1st syllable: qui b) 2nd syllable: et

9. Which syllable is stressed in the word "perfect"?
a) 1st syllable: per b) 2nd syllable: fect

10. Which syllable is stressed in the word "allow"?
a) 1st syllable: a b) 2nd syllable: llow

11. Which syllable is stressed in the word "standard"?
a) 1st syllable: stan b) 2nd syllable: dard

12. Which syllable is stressed in the word "delte"?
a) 1st syllable: de b) 2nd syllable: lete

Watch the Video

Rachel's English - Word Stress in Three-Syllable Words

Video: https://youtu.be/08qBN29mIBs

Practice

Underline the stressed syllable in each of the words below.

Example: comp<u>u</u>ter

1. rational
2. popular
3. decided
4. example
5. everyday
6. eighty-one
7. sensation

Check your Answers

Use the interactive quiz to check your answers. Select the correct answer, click "check" to see if your answer is correct, and then click the arrow to move to the next question. When you have answered all of the questions, click "Finished."

EXERCISE

1. Which syllable is stressed in the word "rational"?
a) 1st syllable: ra b) 2nd syllable: tion c) 3rd syllable: al

2. Which syllable is stressed in the word "popular"?
a) 1st syllable: pop b) 2nd syllable: u c) 3rd syllable: lar

3. Which syllable is stressed in the word "decided"?
a) 1st syllable: de b) 2nd syllable: ci c) 3rd syllable: ded

4. Which syllable is stressed in the word "example"?
a) 1st syllable: e b) 2nd syllable: xam c) 3rd syllable: ple

5. Which syllable is stressed in the word "eighty-one"?
a) 1st syllable: eigh b) 2nd syllable: ty c) 3rd syllable: one

6. Which syllable is stressed in the word "sensation"?
a) 1st syllable: sen b) 2nd syllable: sa c) 3rd syllable: tion

7. Which syllable is stressed in the word "everyday"?

a) 1st syllable: ev b) 2nd syllable: ry c) 3rd syllable: day

Quiz

You will hear each word two times. Underline the strongest (or stressed) syllable. Click here for the audio: (Audio on the lesson web page: "Syllable Stress Quiz") You can listen to the recording as many time as you need.

1. bursting
2. excited
3. memorial
4. dangle
5. escape
6. graffiti
7. dividing
8. covered
9. infamously
10. kilometer
11. explain
12. concoction
13. curry
14. powder
15. popular
16. delicious
17. present (noun)
18. present (verb)

Check your Answers

Use the interactive quiz to check your answers. Select the correct answer, click "check" to see if your answer is correct, and then click the arrow to move to the next question. When you have answered all of the questions, click "Finished."

EXERCISE

Click to highlight the syllable that has the most stress (or emphasis) in each word.

1. burst ing
2. ex ci ted
3. me mo ri al
4. dan gle
5. e scape
6. gra fi ti
7. di vid ing
8. cov ered
9. in fa mous ly
10. kil o me ter
11. ex plain
12. con coc tion
13. cur ry
14. pow der
15. pop u lar
16. de li cious
17. pre sent (noun)
18. pre sent (verb)

Resources

Dictionaries: Finding the Stressed Syllable

Most dictionaries put a ['] before the syllable with the main stress. Sometimes one word can have more than one stress pattern.

Example

- 'pre-sent (noun) - People usually give a **present** for birthdays and weddings.
- pre-'sent (verb) - The scientists will **present** their research.

Click on the link to use the website The Merriam-Webster's Learner's Dictionary: https://learnersdictionary.com/

Watch the video to learn how to use The Merriam-Webster's Learner's Dictionary: Merriam-Webster Learner Dictionary.mp4

How to use howmanysyllables.com

You can use the website https://www.howmanysyllables.com/ to help you count the number of syllables. This website can also help you determine which syllable is stressed.

To use the website How Many Syllables:

- Type the word into the search bar
- Find the number of syllables
- Find the stress
- Play the recording and practice saying the word

Watch the video to learn how to use the website: How Many Syllables.mp4

Click on the link to use the website: https://www.howmanysyllables.com/

Recording: Syllables and Syllable Stress

- Listen to the recording. (Audio on the lesson web page: "Syllable Stress Recording Task") Then say the following words.
- Use the correct stress. Remember that the vowel for the stressed syllable should be long and clear. The vowels in the other syllables are not stressed. They are quick and usually have a schwa sound.
- Submit your video recording to your teacher.
- You will receive one point for each correctly pronounced word.

Total Points: _____/16

1. **burst** ing
2. ex **ci** ted
3. me **mo** ri al
4. **dan** gle
5. es **cape**
6. gra **fi** ti
7. di **vid** ing
8. **cov** ered
9. **in** fa mous ly
10. **kil** o me ter
11. ex **plain**
12. con **coc** tion
13. **cur** ry
14. **pow** der
15. **pop** u lar
16. de **li** cious